



Renault FT-17

The Renault light tank was developed when General Estienne, father of the French tank force in World War I, asked Louis Renault to design a light two-man tank that could support infantry in mass attacks. Renault at first declined since he thought his company lacked experience in such matters, but when asked again in the summer of 1916, he changed his mind and took on the project.

THE RENAULT was essentially a tapered metal box with an engine at the rear and a crew (commander and driver) at the front. It had the very first fully rotating turret, which also had a small dome that could be opened and tilted to ventilate the turret. The armor-plated hull acted as its chassis, and the Renault 35hp engine and gearbox provided five gears (four forward and one reverse). The tank could reach speeds of just under 5mph (8km/h) on the road and had a range of 34km (22 miles). Its small size and weight of just over 7 tons (6 tonnes) meant the tank was easily transportable by truck.

The tank first saw action in May 1918, and two months later 408 broke through the German front at Soissons, although the French cavalry failed to capitalize on their success. It then evolved into a number of variants, and saw service with the US Army in World War I before being sold to many other nations after the war. France still had ten battalions of Renaults in service in September 1939.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	Renault FT-17
Date	1917
Origin	France
Production	3,950
Engine	Renault 4-cylinder gasoline, 35 hp
Weight	7.2 tons (6.5 tonnes)
Main armament	37 mm Puteaux SA 18 (shown here) or 8 mm Hotchkiss Mle 1914
Secondary armament	None
Crew	2
Armor thickness	0.3-0.6 in (8-16 mm)

Engine

Commander

Driver